

# THE HIGHEST PRICE AND THE GREATEST LOVE

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*What Really Happened on the Cross — and Why It Is the Best News in  
the World*

*“God commends his own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners,  
Christ died for us.”*

Romans 5:8 (WEB)

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## A Note on the Scriptures

Every verse is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a public-domain translation free to read, copy, and share. Where the original languages matter — the Greek word Jesus cried from the cross, the Hebrew logic of the blood — we will look underneath the English, but you will not need to know the languages to follow.

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## A Note to Every Reader

The cross is the strangest emblem any movement ever adopted. Imagine a religion whose symbol was an electric chair or a hangman's rope. That is roughly what the first Christians did: they took the most shameful instrument of Roman torture and made it the center of everything, because they were convinced that on one such cross the most important transaction in the history of the world took place.

This book is about that transaction. It asks three plain questions: *What did the cross cost? What did it buy? And what does it ask of you?* The answer, in one sentence, is this: **the cross is the receipt, the blood is the price, and the empty tomb is the proof that the payment was accepted.**

**To the believer:** may this make the gospel vivid again.

**To the skeptic:** you need not believe in advance; only follow the logic of the texts.

**To the one who is weary or ashamed:** read to the end. This book was written for you.

We compare beliefs and never demean people. And we make no apology for where this leads — to an open invitation that costs you nothing because it already cost Someone everything.

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# Chapter One — The Debt We Cannot Pay

## Starting with the bad news, honestly

No one is moved by the cure who has not faced the disease. So the gospel begins with a diagnosis the modern world dislikes: there is something deeply wrong with us, and it is not merely a matter of bad habits or bad luck. The Bible calls it sin — not just the wrong things we do, but a corruption of the heart that puts self where God should be.

*"All have sinned, and fall short of the glory of God." — Romans 3:23 (WEB)*

All. Not most. Not the obviously wicked. The Bible levels the playing field: the respectable and the criminal both fall short. And it is honest about the wage:

*"The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord." — Romans 6:23 (WEB)*

A wage is something *earned* — what we have coming to us. A gift is something *given* — what we could never earn. The whole gospel lives in the gap between those two words.

## Why a holy God cannot simply ignore it

People often ask, "Why doesn't God just forgive and forget? Why does anyone have to die?" It is a fair question, and the answer reveals something about justice we already know in our bones.

Imagine a judge who let every murderer and abuser walk free with a wave of the hand. We would not call that judge loving; we would call that judge corrupt. A good judge cannot simply ignore evil — justice that overlooks real wrong is not mercy, it is the collapse of justice. God is the perfectly good Judge of all the earth. His holiness is not a cold technicality; it is the very thing that guarantees evil will not have the last word. "He will by no means clear the guilty" (Exodus 34:7).

So we face a genuine dilemma — not God's dilemma, but ours. We owe a debt to justice we cannot pay, and a holy God cannot pretend the debt does not exist. How can God be both perfectly just *and* the one who forgives sinners? The entire Old Testament aches toward an answer it cannot quite reach. The cross is where God Himself answers it — at His own expense.

## The size of the love this requires

Hold this in mind as we go, because it changes everything: the measure of a gift is the price the giver was willing to pay. If the cross is the price God paid for us, then the cross is the truest measure of how much we are loved. Not loved because we are good — Romans said we are not. Loved "while we were yet sinners." That is the highest price, and it is the greatest love, and they are the same event.

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# Chapter Two — Why Blood?

## The strangest thread in the Bible

Run your finger down the spine of Scripture and you will find it stained with blood — the lamb at Passover, the sacrifices of the law, the Day of Atonement, and finally a cross. Modern readers recoil. Why is God so concerned with blood? Is this primitive, even barbaric?

The Bible gives a precise reason, and it is not bloodthirstiness but mercy:

*"For the life of the flesh is in the blood. I have given it to you on the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood that makes atonement by reason of the life." — Leviticus 17:11 (WEB)*

The point is *life*. Blood represents life poured out. Atonement — being made "at one" with God — requires a life given in the place of the life that was forfeit. The sacrifices were God's vivid, unforgettable way of teaching a hard truth: sin costs a life, and God in mercy permits a substitute to bear that cost. Every lamb on every altar was a picture saying, *the wages of sin is death — but it can be paid by another*.

## A debt that animals could not actually pay

Here is the catch the Old Testament itself confesses: the blood of bulls and goats never truly settled anything. It was a promissory note, not the payment. "It is impossible that the blood of bulls and goats should take away sins" (Hebrews 10:4). The sacrifices were repeated endlessly — morning and evening, year after year — precisely because none of them finished the job. They were the bill arriving over and over, never marked "paid."

So the whole sacrificial system was a giant arrow pointing forward, asking a question it could not answer: *where is the sacrifice that will actually be enough?* The answer had to be a life of infinite worth, given once.

## "Without shedding of blood there is no remission"

The book of Hebrews states the principle bluntly: "apart from shedding of blood there is no remission" (Hebrews 9:22). This is not God being harsh; it is God being honest about the seriousness of evil. Cheap forgiveness — the kind that costs nothing — would mean our sin never really mattered. The blood says it mattered enormously. And it says God was willing to pay for it Himself.

That is why, when John the Baptist saw Jesus, he did not call Him a great teacher or a wise rabbi. He called Him an animal headed for an altar: "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). After fifteen centuries of lambs, the Lamb had come. To understand His death, we have to sit at His final meal.

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# Chapter Three — The Lamb, the Bread, and the Cup

## A meal that explains a murder

On the night before He died, Jesus did not gather His friends to fight or flee. He gathered them to eat — and the meal He chose was the Passover, the annual remembrance of the lamb whose blood saved Israel. In that loaded setting, He took the two plainest things on the table, bread and wine, and made them the interpretation of His own death.

*"This is my body which is given for you... This cup is the new covenant in my blood, which is poured out for you." — Luke 22:19-20 (WEB)*

Read what He is claiming. The bread *broken*, the cup *poured out* — His body and blood, "given for you." He is telling them, before a single nail is driven, exactly what the cross will mean: not a tragic accident, not a martyr's bad luck, but a sacrifice deliberately given. He is the Passover Lamb, and this is the night the blood is applied.

## The bread and the betrayer

Your own study lingered over a piercing detail of that night — the morsel of bread Jesus handed to His betrayer. Even as Judas prepared to sell Him for thirty pieces of silver (the price, Zechariah had foretold, at which the Shepherd of Israel would be valued — Zechariah 11:12-13), Jesus dipped the bread and gave it to him (John 13:26). The Host fed the man who was selling Him. It is a small window into the whole cross: love extended to the very ones doing the betraying. "While we were yet sinners, Christ died for us."

And the silver itself carries the ancient echo your archive traced — thirty pieces was the price of a slave gored by an ox (Exodus 21:32). The Lord of glory was valued at the price of a dead slave. The injustice was total. The love was greater.

## The cup He did not want to drink

Then comes Gethsemane, where the strongest argument against an unfeeling religion is found — for Jesus did not march to the cross like a stoic. He fell on His face and prayed, "My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass away from me; nevertheless, not what I desire, but what you desire" (Matthew 26:39).

What was "the cup" He dreaded? Throughout the prophets, "the cup" is a picture of God's righteous judgment against sin (Isaiah 51:17; Jeremiah 25:15). Jesus was not merely afraid of the nails — many ordinary people have faced torture bravely. He was facing something no one else ever has: drinking down the full cup of judgment that our sin had filled. He shrank from it as anyone holy would shrink from becoming "sin on our behalf." And then He said *nevertheless* — and rose, and went. The price was about to be paid, and the first thing it would cost Him was the one thing He had never been without.

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# Chapter Four — Forsaken

## The darkest words ever spoken

For three hours at midday, darkness covers the land. And out of the darkness comes the most agonizing sentence in all of Scripture — one of your own Scroll threads, and rightly so, because nothing in the Bible is heavier:

*"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" — Matthew 27:46 (WEB)*

Christians sometimes rush past this cry, embarrassed by it. We should not. Jesus, who had known unbroken fellowship with His Father from eternity, here experiences something He had never known — the turning away of the Father's face. This is the true cost of the cross. The nails were terrible; this was worse. The Son who is "in the bosom of the Father" tasted, for us, the God-forsakenness that our sin deserved.

## Why He quoted Psalm 22

But notice *what* He cried. He was not improvising a complaint; He was quoting Scripture — the opening line of Psalm 22, written a thousand years earlier by David. Read that psalm and the hair stands up on your neck, for it describes the scene in detail no crucifixion victim could have arranged:

*"They have pierced my hands and feet... They divide my garments among them. They cast lots for my clothing." — Psalm 22:16, 18 (WEB)*

Crucifixion did not exist in David's day, yet the psalm describes pierced hands and feet, mockers who "shake their heads," bones out of joint, a tongue cleaving to the jaw with thirst, and soldiers gambling for the sufferer's clothing — all of which the Gospels record at Calvary. By crying its first line, Jesus was hanging a sign over the cross that said: *this is the moment Scripture was describing*. And that psalm, which begins in forsakenness, ends in triumph and worldwide worship: "All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to Yahweh" (Psalm 22:27). Even in the cry of dereliction, He was pointing past the darkness to the victory on the other side.

## The forsaking that ends all forsaking

Here is the heart of it. Jesus was forsaken so that we never need be. He drank the cup of judgment to the dregs so that, for all who trust Him, the cup is empty. The Father turned His

face from the Son so that He could turn His face toward us in welcome. "He was wounded for our transgressions... and by his wounds we are healed" (Isaiah 53:5). The greatest love is measured by the highest price, and the highest price was not the blood alone but the forsaking — God Himself, in the person of the Son, absorbing the cost of our rebellion.

Three hours later, the price was fully paid. And the next word He spoke was not despair. It was a cry of completion.

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# Chapter Five — Barabbas and the Great Exchange

## A guilty man goes free

Hours before the cross, there is a scene that quietly explains the whole thing — the release of a prisoner named Barabbas. Pilate, hoping to free Jesus, offers the crowd a choice between Jesus and a notorious insurrectionist and murderer. The crowd chooses Barabbas. So the guilty man walks out of his cell, and the innocent man takes his place on the cross that was, quite literally, prepared for someone else.

Sit with that picture, because it is the gospel in miniature. Barabbas did nothing to earn his freedom. He did not repent, negotiate, or improve himself. He simply woke up condemned and went to bed free, because Another stood in his place. The cross Jesus carried may well have been the very cross built for Barabbas. The name "Barabbas" even means "son of the father" — and on that morning, the false son of the father went free because the true Son of the Father took his death.

## The great exchange, stated plainly

The New Testament has a phrase for what happened to Barabbas, and to everyone who trusts Christ. It is the great exchange:

*"For him who knew no sin he made to be sin on our behalf; so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." — 2 Corinthians 5:21 (WEB)*

Read it twice. The sinless One was *made to be sin* — treated as if He had lived our life. And we, in return, "become the righteousness of God" — treated as if we had lived His. Our record is laid on Him; His record is laid on us. He gets our cross; we get His crown. This is not God overlooking sin; it is God *transferring* it to a willing Substitute and giving us, in exchange, a righteousness that was never ours.

*"He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree... by whose stripes you were healed." — 1 Peter 2:24 (WEB)*

## Who, then, does the saving?

This is where one of your study threads cuts sharply — *who saves, according to Scripture?* The answer the cross forces on us is uncomfortable to human pride: not us. We are all

Barabbas. We do not save ourselves by our religion, our sincerity, or our improvement, any more than Barabbas talked himself out of prison. "There is salvation in no one else, for neither is there any other name under heaven that is given among men, by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12). Salvation is something done *for* us and given *to* us. Our part is not to pay; our part is to receive — to walk out of the cell that Another emptied.

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# Chapter Six — It Is Finished

## One word from a dying man

The Gospel of John records the last word Jesus spoke before He died — a single word in Greek that He cried out, John says, not as a whimper of defeat but with a loud voice:

*"When Jesus therefore had received the vinegar, he said, 'It is finished!' Then he bowed his head, and gave up his spirit." — John 19:30 (WEB)*

"It is finished" translates one Greek word: **τετέλεσται** (*tetelestai*). And here is the detail your archive rightly seized on — in the first-century world, that exact word was written across business documents and stamped on bills. *Tetelestai* meant **"paid in full."** It was the word you wrote on a certificate of debt when the last payment had been made and the obligation was discharged forever.

So the last thing Jesus said was not "I am finished" — a victim's surrender. It was "It is finished" — a victor's announcement. *The debt is paid in full. The price is met. There is nothing left to pay.*

## The certificate of debt, nailed to the cross

Paul takes up the same picture and tells us what was nailed to the cross along with Jesus:

*"having wiped out the handwriting in ordinances which was against us... and he has taken it out of the way, nailing it to the cross." — Colossians 2:14 (WEB)*

"The handwriting in ordinances which was against us" — the record of debt, the charge sheet with our name on it and every count against us. Paul says God did not merely set it aside; He *cancelled* it and nailed it to the cross, so that it can never be presented against us again. This is why the cross is the receipt. It is the cancelled bill, stamped *tetelestai*, hung up for the universe to see.

## What "finished" does not mean

It is worth saying clearly what was *not* finished. Jesus was not saying His mission was over in defeat, nor that there was nothing more to come — the resurrection was three days away. He was saying that the *work of atonement* — the paying of the price for sin — was complete. Nothing needs to be added to it. No further sacrifice, no penance, no good works can supplement a payment that is already "in full." This is why the gospel is good *news* rather than

good *advice*. Advice tells you what you must do. News tells you what has been done. The cross is news: it is finished.

If the debt is truly paid, only one question remains — how do we know the payment was accepted? For that, we need the morning of the third day.

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# Chapter Seven — The Receipt, the Proof, and the Invitation

## Why the resurrection is not optional

A cancelled debt is only good news if the creditor agrees it is paid. So how do we know God accepted the price Jesus offered? Because three days later, God raised Him from the dead. The resurrection is the Father's public receipt — His "amen" to the Son's "it is finished."

*"[He] was delivered up for our trespasses, and was raised for our justification." — Romans 4:25 (WEB)*

Had Jesus stayed in the tomb, the cross would be one more tragic execution and the bill would still be unpaid. But the empty tomb is God's declaration that the sacrifice was sufficient, the Substitute vindicated, death itself defeated. Paul is so certain of this that he stakes everything on it: "if Christ has not been raised, your faith is vain; you are still in your sins" (1 Corinthians 15:17). Christianity is not a set of timeless principles that would survive being disproved. It is a claim about an event. And the earliest record we have — a creed Paul says he "received" and passed on within a few years of the events — already proclaims that Christ "was buried... was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures, and... appeared" to hundreds of witnesses, "most of whom remain until now" (1 Corinthians 15:3-6).

## The Shepherd who came for the lost

Step back and ask *why* — why would God pay such a price for people who, like Barabbas, had earned only the cell? Jesus answered with a picture your study returned to: the shepherd and the lost sheep. "What man of you, if he had one hundred sheep, and lost one of them, wouldn't leave the ninety-nine... and go after the one that was lost, until he found it?" (Luke 15:4). He told that story to explain why He, the friend of sinners, was always to be found among the very people the religious had given up on.

This is the answer to the highest-price question. He did not pay it because we were a good investment. He paid it because He is a Shepherd who will not abandon the one. "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep" (John 10:11). The cross is what it looks like when the Shepherd goes after the lost and refuses to come home without them.

## The invitation that costs you nothing

Which brings us, finally, to you. If the price is paid in full, if the payment is accepted, if the Shepherd is even now seeking the lost — then the gospel ends not with a demand but with an open hand:

*"He who believes in the Son has eternal life." — John 3:36 (WEB)*

You cannot add to "it is finished." You can only receive it or refuse it. Receiving it is what the Bible calls faith and repentance — turning from your sin and trusting Christ alone, calling on Him as Barabbas might have turned to thank the man who took his cross. "If you will confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (Romans 10:9).

You could do that right now, in your own words, wherever you are. Something as simple as: *Lord Jesus, I have sinned and I cannot save myself. I believe you died in my place and rose again. Thank you that it is finished. I turn from my sin and trust you alone. Be my Lord and my Savior.*

If you mean it, then the highest price has bought the greatest gift, and it is yours — not because you paid, but because He did.

*"Most certainly I tell you, he who hears my word, and believes him who sent me, has eternal life, and doesn't come into judgment, but has passed out of death into life."  
— John 5:24 (WEB)*

It is finished. Come and receive it.

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# Honest Questions

The cross provokes hard questions, and faith is not afraid of them. Here are the ones most worth pressing, answered plainly.

## "Why couldn't God just forgive, without anyone dying?"

Because real forgiveness is never free for the one who forgives — someone always absorbs the cost. If you forgive a debt owed to you, *you* bear the loss; the money does not reappear. A judge who simply waved away every crime would not be merciful but corrupt, and we would rightly protest. God's dilemma (really *ours*) is how to be both perfectly just — taking evil seriously — and the one who pardons sinners. "Just forgiving" would mean sin never truly mattered. The cross is God's answer: He does not ignore the debt; He *pays it Himself*, in His Son, so He can be "just, and the justifier of him who has faith in Jesus" (Romans 3:26). Justice satisfied; sinner forgiven; the cost borne by God.

## "Isn't punishing an innocent man for the guilty unjust?"

It would be — if the cross were God taking a random innocent bystander and venting wrath on him. But that is not the Christian claim. The One who bears the penalty is not a third party; He is God Himself, in the person of the Son, voluntarily taking the cost upon Himself. "God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself" (2 Corinthians 5:19). No one imposed this on an unwilling victim: "I lay down my life... No one takes it away from me, but I lay it down by myself" (John 10:17-18). When the offended party chooses to absorb the debt personally and willingly, that is not injustice — it is the highest love.

## "Isn't this 'cosmic child abuse' — the Father punishing the Son?"

This objection misreads the Trinity. The Father and the Son are not two separate beings, one harming the other; they are one God, of one mind and one will, acting together to save. The Son is not a helpless child dragged to the cross by an angry parent; He is the eternal God who "loved me, and gave himself up for me" (Galatians 2:20), in perfect unity with the Father whose love "commends" itself precisely *in* the giving (Romans 5:8). The cross is not the Father against the Son; it is the one God, Father and Son and Spirit, against our sin and *for* us, at infinite cost to Himself.

## "If salvation is free and finished, can't people just sin all they want?"

Paul asked the very same question — "Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound?" — and answered, "May it never be!" (Romans 6:1-2). Grace is free, but it is not cheap, and it is never *inert*. The same gospel that forgives also transforms: those truly united to Christ have "died to sin" and are made new, given His Spirit, taught to "walk in newness of life" (Romans 6:4). A person who treats forgiveness as a license to keep sinning has not understood it — and may not yet have received it. Grace does not leave us where it found us; it is the very power that frees us *from* sin, not merely from its penalty. We obey not to *earn* the gift but because we have *received* it.

## "How can one man's death pay for the sins of the whole world?"

Because of *who* He is. If Jesus were merely a man, His death could at most stand in for one other man. But the One on the cross is the eternal Son of God, of infinite worth — and so His one sacrifice has infinite value, sufficient for all. "He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not for ours only, but also for the whole world" (1 John 2:2). This is why it matters so much that the Bible insists on His deity (see our companion books *Hear, O Israel* and *I Am He*): only a sacrifice of infinite worth could pay a debt this large, "once for all" (Hebrews 10:10).

## "What about those who never hear of Jesus?"

Scripture says less about this than we might wish, and we should resist the urge to invent answers God did not give. But we can say three true things. First, God is perfectly just *and* perfectly merciful — the Judge of all the earth will do right (Genesis 18:25), and no one will be treated unfairly. Second, everyone has *some* light — the witness of creation and conscience (Romans 1:19-20) — and is responsible for what they do with it. Third, this question is most honestly faced by the one asking it: *you* have now heard. The uncertainty about others is not a reason to delay your own response to the One who is, at this moment, standing before you with an empty cross and an open hand.

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## Appendix — Key Texts on the Cross

A reference table of the threads traced in this book.

| Truth                        | Key text (WEB)                                                                            |
|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| All have sinned              | "All have sinned, and fall short of the glory of God." (Romans 3:23)                      |
| The wage and the gift        | "The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life." (Romans 6:23)      |
| Life is in the blood         | "It is the blood that makes atonement by reason of the life." (Leviticus 17:11)           |
| No remission without blood   | "Apart from shedding of blood there is no remission." (Hebrews 9:22)                      |
| The Lamb of God              | "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29)               |
| The cup of judgment          | "Let this cup pass away from me; nevertheless, not what I desire." (Matthew 26:39)        |
| The forsaking                | "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matthew 27:46; Psalm 22:1)                   |
| The great exchange           | "Him who knew no sin he made to be sin on our behalf." (2 Corinthians 5:21)               |
| Paid in full                 | "It is finished!" (John 19:30 — Greek <i>tetelestai</i> )                                 |
| The cancelled debt           | "...nailing it to the cross." (Colossians 2:14)                                           |
| Raised for our justification | "...delivered up for our trespasses, and was raised for our justification." (Romans 4:25) |
| Received by faith            | "If you will confess... and believe... you will be saved." (Romans 10:9)                  |

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## Conclusion — The Receipt, Framed

The cross is the receipt. The blood is the price. The empty tomb is the proof that the payment was accepted. Everything the Old Testament was reaching for — the lamb, the blood, the scapegoat, the suffering servant — was paid out in full on one Friday afternoon, and confirmed on one Sunday morning.

The highest price was paid by the greatest love, for people who had earned only the cell. That is the gospel. It asks nothing of you that you could pay, because it has already been paid. It asks only that you come.

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### About this book

*The Highest Price and the Greatest Love* is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry**, that the earth may be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. It may be read, shared, and given away without charge. All Scripture is from the World English Bible (public domain). We hold the historic Nicene faith and the plain reading of Scripture; we compare beliefs and never demean persons.

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*"Christ in you, the hope of glory." — Colossians 1:27 (WEB)*